

INTRODUCTION TO THEOLOGY

Comprehensive BTh Study Notes for the Indian Context

PART SIX: Interpretation and the Methods of Biblical Criticism

Prepared for Bachelor of Theology students. These notes are self-contained. This final part teaches you how to read the Bible rightly: the principles of Catholic interpretation, the rules given by the Second Vatican Council, and the scholarly methods used to study the sacred text. At the end you will find a closing charge that gathers the whole course together.

1. Why Interpretation Matters: The Danger of Private Reading

We begin with a warning from Scripture itself. Saint Peter writes: "First of all you must understand this, that no prophecy of scripture is a matter of one's own interpretation" (2 Peter 1:20, RSV-2CE).

This single verse overturns a very common modern assumption: the idea that anyone can pick up the Bible, open it anywhere, and decide for himself what it means. The Bible was **not** given to isolated individuals to interpret by private whim. It was given to the believing **community**, the Church, to be read within the living stream of the faith.

Why is private, context-less reading so dangerous? Because a verse torn from its setting can be twisted to mean almost anything. This is exactly the method of the heretic we met in Part One, who corrupts truth "by invalid argumentations on scripture."

Key Points:

- Scripture is not "a matter of one's own interpretation" (2 Peter 1:20). It is read rightly within the Church.
- A verse ripped from its context can be bent to serve any agenda.
- Right interpretation is a discipline with rules, not a free-for-all.

Indian Context Example:

No tradition understands this better than India. In the classical Indian view, one does **not** simply read the sacred text alone and decide its meaning for oneself. The scripture is received **under a guru**, within a recognised **sampradaya** (lineage), because the guru carries the authentic key to the text's meaning. A verse of the Upanishads read without the guru's guidance can be badly misunderstood, which is precisely why the tradition insists on the teacher. The Catholic principle is the very same instinct: Scripture is read within the community and its living Tradition, not by private guesswork. When you teach this to Indian students, tell them: as you would never claim to master the Gita by reading it alone without a guru, so no Christian should claim to master the Bible by private interpretation apart from the Church.

A classic and much-loved piece of humour:

There is an old story of a worried man who decided to find God's will by opening the Bible at random and pointing to a verse. The first time, his finger landed on the end of Matthew 27:5, "and he went and hanged himself." Alarmed, he tried again, and landed on Luke 10:37, "Go and do likewise." Now truly frightened, he tried a third time, and landed on John 13:27, "What you are going to do, do quickly." Every seminarian laughs at this, and then understands the lesson in his bones: the Bible is not a magic lottery, and a verse without its context can lead you anywhere, even off a cliff. Read the whole, read the context, read within the Church.

Application:

Your people will be tempted to use the Bible as a fortune-teller's book, opening it at random for "a word for today." Gently teach them a better way: to read whole passages, in context, within the mind of the Church. You will protect them from both silliness and error.

2. Historical-Critical Exegesis

The Church's most authoritative teaching on interpreting Scripture is found in the Second Vatican Council's Dogmatic Constitution on Divine Revelation, **Dei Verbum**, especially section 12 (see also the Catechism of the Catholic Church, nos. 109 to 114).

Dei Verbum endorses a serious, scholarly reading of Scripture called **historical-critical exegesis**. The name has two parts, and each part matters:

- It is **historical** because it goes back to the real historical contexts in which the biblical texts were formed. It takes seriously that the Bible was written by real people in real times and places.
- It is **critical** (from the Greek for "judgment") because it requires trained professional knowledge and careful judgment to determine, as far as possible, what the writer wanted to communicate and what sources he used.

Note carefully: "critical" here does **not** mean attacking or criticising the Bible in a negative sense. It means exercising informed **judgment**, the way a wise judge weighs evidence.

Key Points:

- Dei Verbum 12 is the Church's charter for interpreting Scripture.
- **Historical-critical exegesis** reads the Bible in its real historical setting, using trained judgment.
- "Critical" means "exercising judgment," not "finding fault."

Indian Context Example:

The word "criticism" causes needless alarm, so an Indian comparison helps. Indian scholarship has its own long and honoured tradition of textual judgment. The great scholars

who prepared the **critical edition of the Mahabharata** at the Bhandarkar Oriental Research Institute in Pune spent decades comparing thousands of manuscripts to establish the most reliable text. No one accuses them of "attacking" the Mahabharata; they were **serving** it with rigorous scholarly judgment. Biblical criticism is exactly this kind of loving, disciplined service of the sacred text, not an attack upon it.

Illustration:

Think of a master goldsmith testing a piece of gold. He weighs it, examines it, and applies careful tests, not because he despises the gold but because he honours it and wants to know its true worth. Biblical criticism is the goldsmith's careful testing, applied in reverence to the Word of God, so that we may know its true meaning.

Application:

Do not let anyone frighten you or your people away from serious biblical study by shouting the word "criticism." Explain calmly that critical study, rightly done, is reverent study. The Church herself commands it.

3. The Principles of Interpretation

Dei Verbum and Catholic scholarship give us clear principles for reading Scripture well. Learn these four, in order.

3.1 First Principle: Identify the Genre (the Kind of Literature)

Before you can understand a text, you must know **what kind of writing it is**. Scholars call this the **genre** of the text: is it narrative, prophecy, poetry, history, gospel, or epistle (letter)? You read each genre by its own rules. You do not read a poem the way you read a legal contract, and you do not read a parable the way you read a newspaper report.

3.2 Second Principle: Consider the Context

This is often called the first and most important principle of all. **Context** means the whole setting of the passage: historical, social, political, religious, and above all **literary** (what comes before and after the passage in the text itself). A verse gets its meaning from its neighbours. Pull it out of its context, and you can make it say almost anything, as our random-opening joke showed.

3.3 Third Principle: Discern the Writer's Intention

You must try to discover what the **writer actually intended** to communicate. This is the principle of **intentionality**, and it is critical for the preacher. You study a text not to find a clever sermon in it, but to discover the writer's intended message. And here is the golden rule to memorise, the one line every expository preacher should write inside his notebook:

■ **"The text cannot mean what it never meant."**

Your first task is to discover the original meaning the writer intended for the first hearers. Only then are you ready to preach it to your own generation.

3.4 Fourth Principle: Consider the Tradition of the Church

The most important **norm** in Catholic interpretation is the authentic **Tradition of the Church**. The Bible was given to the believing community of the disciples of Jesus, not to isolated individuals. Only the community, acting under the guidance of the Holy Spirit through its appointed leaders, is empowered to define the teaching of Scripture. The Church today reads the Bible within the long tradition of interpretation across the centuries, in order to find the constant, reliable meaning.

Key Points (the four principles):

1. **Genre:** know what kind of writing it is.
2. **Context:** read the passage within its whole setting, especially the surrounding text.
3. **Intention:** seek the writer's intended meaning; the text cannot mean what it never meant.
4. **Tradition:** read within the community and Tradition of the Church, the most important norm of all.

Indian Context Example (a remarkable parallel):

India possesses an entire classical science devoted to exactly this task of interpretation. It is called **Purva Mimamsa**, and its whole purpose is to establish the rules for correctly interpreting the sacred Vedic texts. Astonishingly, the Mimamsa scholars developed a set of principles that map almost exactly onto the Catholic ones. To determine the true purport of a text, which they called **tatparya**, they taught the interpreter to weigh such marks as the **beginning and the conclusion** of the passage (upakrama and upasamhara), its **repetition** (abhyasa), its **result or purpose** (phala), and its supporting **reasoning** (upapatti). In plain terms, the classical Indian interpreter, like the Catholic exegete, asks: What is the context? What is the writer driving at? What is the intended purport? The Indian category of **tatparya**, "the intended purport of the text," is virtually the twin of the Christian rule that "the text cannot mean what it never meant." When you teach interpretation in India, you can tell your students with pride that their own soil produced one of the oldest and most sophisticated sciences of textual interpretation in the world, and that its instincts confirm the Church's own.

A gentle piece of humour about genre:

A student once complained that the Bible was "full of contradictions" because it says God is a rock (Psalm 18:2), and also that we should hide under the shadow of God's wings (Psalm 17:8). "So which is it," he demanded, "a rock or a bird?" The answer, with a smile, is: neither, and both, because this is **poetry**, and poetry speaks in images. To read a psalm as if it were a zoology report is to misunderstand the genre, and to end up looking for a feathered stone. Know the genre, and the "contradiction" vanishes into beauty.

Application:

These four principles are your daily tools as a preacher. Before every homily, ask: What genre is this? What is the context? What did the writer intend? What does the Church's Tradition make of it? A homily built on these four is honest, and it will feed your people the true bread of the Word, not the stones of your own opinions.

4. Dei Verbum 12 and Its Three Rules

Beyond the general principles, Dei Verbum 12 gives a golden rule and three specific criteria that every Catholic interpreter must follow.

The golden rule is this: "Holy Scripture must be read and interpreted in the same Spirit through whom it was written" (Dei Verbum, no. 12). The Bible was written **in** the Holy Spirit, so it must be read **in** the same Holy Spirit. Scholarly tools are necessary, but they are not enough by themselves. Prayerful reading in the Spirit is essential.

From this flow **three rules**:

1. **Attention to the content and unity of the whole Bible.** The Bible is one book, unified by the single plan of God, and **Christ Jesus is its centre and heart**. No passage may be read in a way that breaks the unity of the whole, or that loses sight of Christ.
2. **Attention to the living Tradition of the whole Church.** Scripture is written principally in the heart of the Church, which carries Tradition, the living memory of the Word of God. We read the text within that living memory.
3. **Attention to the harmony among the elements of the faith.** This is often called the **analogy of faith**. Since all the truths of the faith fit together in harmony, no interpretation of one passage may be allowed to contradict another established truth of the faith.

Key Points:

- The golden rule: read Scripture **in the same Spirit** through whom it was written. Scholarship alone is not enough.
- The three rules: attend to (1) the **unity** of the whole Bible with Christ at its heart, (2) the **living Tradition** of the Church, and (3) the **harmony** of the faith (the analogy of faith).

Indian Context Example:

The principle that each part of a sacred text must be read in harmony with the **whole**, and in the same spirit in which it was composed, is deeply Indian. A traditional interpreter of the Gita does not read a single verse in isolation but in the light of the whole teaching and its central purpose, and always in the reverent spirit of a devotee, not the cold spirit of a fault-finder. The Christian rule is the same: read every passage in the light of the whole Bible, whose heart is Christ, and in the same reverent Spirit in which it was written.

Illustration:

Consider a single note played on a sitar. By itself the note is neither right nor wrong; its rightness depends on the whole raga to which it belongs. A note that would be beautiful in one raga is a mistake in another. Each verse of Scripture is a note; the whole Bible, centred on Christ, is the raga. You interpret the single verse rightly only when you hear it within the whole song. This is the unity rule of Dei Verbum in a single image.

Application:

When you interpret a hard passage, run it through the three rules. Does my reading fit the whole Bible with Christ at its heart? Does it agree with the living Tradition of the Church? Does it harmonise with the other truths of the faith? If your reading fails any of these three, it is wrong, however clever it seems. These three rules are guard-rails that will keep you on the road.

5. The Methods of Biblical Criticism

Finally, we survey the scholarly **methods** used in the professional study of the Bible. Remember once more: "criticism" here comes from the Greek word for **judgment**, and carries nothing negative. It simply means making informed scholarly judgments about the biblical literature: its dating, authorship, historical background, sources, literary forms, and meaning.

Learn these five methods by name and by what each one does.

5.1 Textual Criticism

Aim: to establish the **original and most authoritative text**. Because we have thousands of ancient manuscripts, and they contain small differences (from copyists' slips), textual criticism carefully compares them to recover, as closely as possible, what the original writers actually wrote.

5.2 Source Criticism

Aim: to establish the **oral and written sources** a biblical author used. Just as a modern author draws on earlier materials, the biblical writers often used sources. Source criticism tries to identify them (for example, the material Luke gathered for his Gospel, as he himself mentions in Luke 1:1-4).

5.3 Literary Criticism

Aim: to study the text **as a work of literature**: its style, its structure, its distinctive language, and its literary forms. It asks how the text is built and how it achieves its effect.

5.4 Form Criticism

Aim: to study the particular **literary form** of a small unit (for example, a myth, a narrative, a hymn, or a parable) in its **oral stage**, and to recover its **original life setting**. Scholars use the

German phrase **Sitz im Leben**, meaning "the setting in life," to name the real-life situation (such as worship, teaching, or preaching) in which a unit first took shape and was used.

5.5 Redaction Criticism

Aim: to study how the **final author**, called the **redactor** (editor), assembled and arranged the material in order to express his own **theological emphasis**. For example, redaction criticism asks why Matthew arranged the teachings of Jesus into five great sermons, and what theological point he was making by doing so.

Key Points (the five methods):

1. **Textual criticism:** recovering the original text from the manuscripts.
2. **Source criticism:** identifying the sources the author used.
3. **Literary criticism:** studying the text as literature (style, structure, form).
4. **Form criticism:** studying small units in their oral stage and life-setting (*Sitz im Leben*).
5. **Redaction criticism:** studying how the final editor arranged the text to make a theological point.

Indian Context Example:

Indian textual scholarship offers real parallels to several of these methods. **Textual criticism** is exactly what the scholars at Pune did in producing the critical edition of the Mahabharata: comparing manuscripts to recover the most reliable text. **Source and redaction criticism** have a parallel in the study of how the Vedic corpus was built up in layers (Samhita, Brahmana, Aranyaka, Upanishad), each layer added and arranged for its own purpose, and in the recognition that the great epics grew through stages of composition and editing. The Indian scholarly tradition already knows that a great sacred text can have a real history of formation, sources, and editing, without losing its sacredness. This helps your students receive the biblical methods calmly, as tools of reverent scholarship rather than threats to faith.

A piece of humour about scholarly jargon:

Biblical scholars have a weakness for impressive German phrases, and **Sitz im Leben** is their favourite. It sounds tremendously learned, and students are often intimidated by it, until they learn that it simply means "setting in life," which is to say, "where and why this was first used." Tell your students, with a smile, that half the art of surviving a theology examination is discovering that the terrifying German phrase usually means something quite simple in plain Bengali or English. Learn the plain meaning first, and the jargon loses its power to frighten you.

Application:

You will not use these five methods every day at the parish level, but you must understand them, for two reasons. First, so that you are not shaken when a professor or a book uses them; you will know they are reverent tools. Second, so that your own preaching quietly

benefits from their fruit: a homily informed by good textual, literary, and redaction study is richer, truer, and safer than one built on guesswork. Use the scholarship humbly, in service of the pulpit.

PART SIX SUMMARY: Main Takeaways

1. Scripture is "not a matter of one's own interpretation" (2 Peter 1:20). It is read within the **community and Tradition of the Church**, just as India reads its scriptures under the guru and within the sampradaya.
 2. The Church endorses **historical-critical exegesis**: reading the Bible in its real historical setting with trained judgment. "Critical" means **judgment**, not fault-finding.
 3. The **four principles of interpretation** are: (1) identify the **genre**, (2) consider the **context**, (3) discern the writer's **intention** ("the text cannot mean what it never meant"), and (4) read within the **Tradition** of the Church. India's own **Purva Mimamsa**, with its science of **tatparya** (intended purport), independently reached the same instincts.
 4. **Dei Verbum 12** gives the golden rule (read Scripture in the same **Spirit** through whom it was written) and **three rules**: attend to the **unity** of the whole Bible with Christ at its heart, the **living Tradition** of the Church, and the **harmony** of the faith (the analogy of faith).
 5. The **five methods of biblical criticism** are: **textual** (recover the original text), **source** (find the sources used), **literary** (study it as literature), **form** (study small units and their life-setting, the Sitz im Leben), and **redaction** (study how the final editor arranged the text to make a theological point).
 6. All of this scholarship is the reverent service of the Word, never an attack upon it, and it exists finally to serve the pulpit and the people.
-

CAPSTONE: Gathering the Whole Course Together

You have now completed the six parts of Introduction to Theology. Before you close the book, let us gather the whole journey into a single view, the way a traveler pauses at the end of a pilgrimage and looks back over the road he has walked.

In **Part One** you learned what theology **is**: God-talk, taught by God, teaching about God, and leading to God, a science to be studied on the knees, with its six marks and its six sources.

In **Part Two** you saw the four **branches** of the one banyan tree: biblical, historical, systematic, and practical theology, each needing the others.

In **Part Three** you walked the long **history** of theology, from the Evangelists through the Fathers and their four great councils, through the scholastics and their marriage of faith

and reason, to the open windows of the Second Vatican Council.

In **Part Four** you came to know the **Bible** itself: its name, its canon, the seven deuterocanonical books, and its great translations, right down to the Bengali Bible born across the river at Serampore.

In **Part Five** you grasped the mystery of **inspiration**: Scripture as the God-breathed word of two true authors, divine and human, teaching saving truth without error.

And in **Part Six** you have learned to **interpret** that word rightly, with genre and context and intention, within the Spirit and the Tradition of the Church, aided by the reverent tools of scholarship.

Now hold all six together, because they make one thing. They make **you**: a minister of the Word who knows what theology is, holds its branches together, remembers its long story, reveres the Bible, understands its inspiration, and interprets it faithfully for the people of God.

Remember the mango tree from the very first page. You have been trained to study the tree that your people already love, so that you may serve their love and guard it from the counterfeit. You have been trained on your knees. Now go and feed the flock: in the villages and towns of Bengal, among the Dalit and the Adivasi, the migrant and the widow, the doubting student and the simple grandmother. Give them the true bread of the Word, broken open with learning and served with love.

That, and nothing less, is why you have studied Introduction to Theology.

Study on your knees. Preach with joy. Guard the flock.

End of Part Six, and end of the complete six-part study notes for Introduction to Theology.